concern ‘about the crisis in the family in many countries’. It declares that ‘Orthodox and Catholics share the same conception of the family […] based on marriage, an act of freely given and faithful love between a man and a woman’ and regrets ‘that other forms of cohabitation have been placed on the same level as this union’.[205] Apparently, for the sake of Christian unity and other pressing issues, Pope Francis agreed on a text that he had himself, in his own pastoral practice, in many ways already surpassed or at least complemented with a compassion and openness, unknown in the reasoning of the Russian Orthodox Church. In fact, within the first six years of Pope Francis’s pontificate, President Putin visited the Vatican no less than three times – ‘a privilege that the pope has not given to any other international leader.’[206] This has certainly added to Putin’s image as a *defensor fidei*,[207] whether intended or not.

There may be several reasons behind the pope’s hospitality, e.g. his ecumenical efforts to bring the Churches closer and his view of the Orthodox Church as a rare ally on certain issues. After all, Pope Francis *is* a defender of family values, though understood in a broader context. However in a political sense, the pope’s actions are at least in part seen as relativising the authoritarian nature of Putin; Matzuzzi concludes that ‘Francis refuses a narrow choice between democracy and autocracy, between black and white’,[208] although this is done out of his primary concern to save what can be saved, including with his new Eastern Politics versus China. This is intriguing given that Pope Francis has been also very critical of populism, saying that its various forms ‘deform the meaning of the word “people” by hitching it to ideologies that focus on perceived enemies, internal and external’.[209] But reading the current pope is not easy, as he equally detests unfettered liberalism: ‘If one worldview exalts and promotes the atomised individual, leaving little room for fraternity and solidarity, the other reduces the people to a faceless mass it claims to represent.’[210]

Pope Francis is thus walking a very narrow road in which (for pragmatic reasons) he is also willing to talk to the likes of Putin (or Patriarch Kirill of Moscow), but above all wants to defend basic tenets of Christian faith and tradition, including strong emphasis on what are usually termed ‘family values’, now increasingly with a negative connotation in secular circles. At the same time he does not want to be seen in the camp of ultra-